

JBL Live 780NC

Best headphones under ₹16000

While flagship headphones often showcase a brand's best technologies, it is the mid-premium segment where the real competition lies. Buyers today expect far more than they did a few years ago, and thankfully, they no longer have to make major compromises to get features like active noise cancellation, multipoint connectivity or long battery life. The JBL Live 780NC is JBL's latest attempt to stand out in this crowded space. It is priced at Rs 15999 and offers 40mm drivers, JBL Signature Sound, True Adaptive Noise Cancelling 2.0, multipoint connectivity and a foldable design, all wrapped in several vibrant colour options. I spent the past few weeks using it for work, commute and entertainment to find out how well these features translate into everyday use, and what compromises accompany.

PHYSICAL CONTROLS

JBL has provided a volume rocker on the left earcup, while the right earcup houses the on/off/manual pairing switch, Auracast button and a USB-C port. So, you get all the required controls. The buttons are tactile and easily reachable.

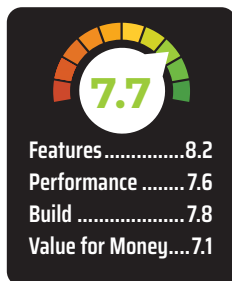
The company has also given touch controls here, on the right earcup. They work, but not always reliably. Finger taps don't register. Taps with my palm work, but even then, triple taps were hit or miss. Also, the touch area can trigger accidental taps, resulting in unwanted pauses.

Thankfully, both touch and button controls are customisable, and you can choose whatever works better for you

SOFTWARE

The JBL Headphones app is one of the

₹14,999



strongest aspects of the ownership experience. I am very familiar with it, having used it with the Tour Pro 3 series. It is one of the most feature-rich companion apps out there.

You don't have to create an account to access any features. You pair the headphones and begin customising them.

The app offers:

- Adaptive ANC controls, including Ambient Aware (transparency mode) and TalkThru (pause playback and talk to someone)
- Multipoint management
- Auracast
- Touch control customisation, as mentioned in the previous section
- 10-band equaliser
- Personi-Fi for calibrating audio output to your ears
- Wear detection: Auto Play and Pause
- Spatial Sound
- LE Audio and LDAC

While some of these features are table-stakes in headphones priced at the 10-16K price range, JBL has some features that set it apart. For starters, it is the only model here with Bluetooth 6.0, making it the most future-ready in terms of wireless connectivity.

I was excited to use features like Auracast, which allows the Live 780NC to broadcast audio to other compatible devices nearby for a shared listening experience. The 10-band equaliser gives granular control, and then there is Personi-Fi, which performs a hearing test and creates a personalised and clearer sound profile based on your hearing ability.

And everything from the initial pairing experience to everyday use with multiple devices, Live 780NC worked reliably. It connects to my laptop and phone simultaneously, but I must pause the first device before the second one can play. This manual switching feels limiting and something found on budget-tier headphones.

BATTERY LIFE

JBL claims up to 80 hours without ANC and 50 hours with ANC enabled. I got closer to those estimates. I played a FLAC music file continuously with ANC and LDAC at 80% volume, and the Live 780NC ran for hours. So, this can easily be a pair of headphones that you carry for a long weekend trip, or use for several days without worrying about charging.

This also means you can forget to charge it and realise when you are heading out somewhere. Gladly, fast charging support is there. Plug it in for 5 minutes, and you can extend its life for another 4 hours. That should be plenty long for a daily commute.

And let's not forget JBL also offers 3.5mm wired listening support. But the only catch is that wired mode works only when the headphones are powered on. That's such an unnecessary limitation!

CUSTOMISABLE SOUND

JBL's tuning would please most